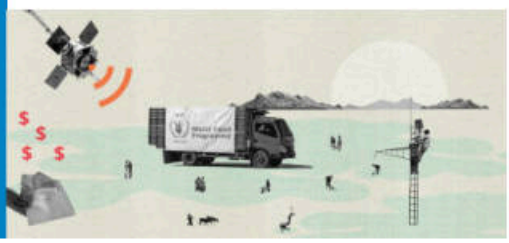
WFP
World Food Programme

SAVING LIVES
CHANGING LIVES

Anticipatory Action Activation

El Salvador, Honduras, Guatemala and Nicaragua





Anticipatory Action ahead of El Niño: WFP's regional response across the Primera and Postrera seasons in the Dry Corridor, Central America

The World Food Programme (WFP) has activated the Anticipatory Action programme in four countries in Central America: El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras and Nicaragua. This collaborative effort with national governments and humanitarian partners aims to safeguard over 100,000 people and their livelihoods in anticipation of the projected impacts of El Niño-induced drought.

Following the activation of drought triggers for the Primera season in March 2026, WFP implemented anticipatory actions ahead of anticipated rainfall deficits. Continued climate monitoring throughout the year subsequently indicated severe rainfall deficits for that drought conditions were also likely to affect the Postrera season, triggering a second, targeted activation window for anticipatory action in El Salvador, Guatemala and Honduras.

The Central American Dry Corridor faces recurrent climatic shocks and high climate variability linked to El Niño, which historically results in below-average rainfall, prolonged dry spells and severe agricultural losses. Seasonal forecasts from the European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts (ECMWF), monitored through OCHA's Centre for Humanitarian Data (CHD), projected significant rainfall deficits for both agricultural seasons, prompting anticipatory action before impacts materialized.

The regional framework monitors drought risk through two activation windows aligned with the Primera and Postrera agricultural seasons. Predefined thresholds determine when forecasts warrant anticipatory action, allowing WFP and partners to intervene before forecast rainfall deficits affect food security and agricultural livelihoods.

The first activation supported vulnerable households ahead of the Primera season, when farmers depend on early rainfall to plant staple crops such as maize and beans. However, updated seasonal forecasts indicated that drought risk would continue into the Postrera season, creating the prospect of further agricultural losses and deterioration in household food security.

The Postrera activation is therefore not an extension of the same assistance to the same beneficiary group. It is a second, targeted intervention responding to forecast drought impacts during a different agricultural window. In El Salvador, Guatemala and Honduras, WFP is providing anticipatory cash assistance to newly targeted households in locations identified as highly exposed to rainfall deficits and related production losses. This assistance aims to protect food consumption and agricultural livelihoods and reduce households' reliance on negative coping strategies before the anticipated impacts materialize.

This marks one of the largest coordinated anticipatory interventions in the region, jointly implemented by WFP, FAO, UNICEF and PAHO, under the OCHA-facilitated regional CERF Anticipatory Action Framework. WFP's contribution to the multi-sector drought AA package totals USD 4.6 million and includes anticipatory cash transfers, early warning dissemination, agricultural inputs and shock-responsive school feeding, tailored by country.

AA Activation—March and Augusts 2026